Communicating with the Public - Role-Play Scenarios

Purpose: Practice clear, empathetic, and accurate communication using real-world situations.

INSTRUCTIONS:

- Break into pairs, small groups, or large groups depending on class size.
- Assign roles: Communicator and Public.
- After each role-play, discuss:
  - Was the message clear?
  - Was the tone respectful?
  - Were questions answered accurately?

SCENARIO 1

Announcing a Community Event

Context: Your organization is hosting a free health fair next month.

Communicator Task: Explain event details and encourage participation.

Public Questions:

- *Is it really free?*
- *What services will be available?*
- *Do I need to register?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 2

Responding to a Complaint

Context: A resident is upset about a recent change in trash collection days.

Communicator Task: Respond calmly, explain the reason for the change, and offer solutions.

Public Questions:

- *Why wasn't I told?*
- *This is inconvenient for me!*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

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SCENARIO 3

Emergency Alert

Context: A severe storm is approaching, and you need to inform the public about safety measures.

Communicator Task: Deliver a clear, urgent message with instructions.

Public Questions:

- *Where can we go for shelter?*
- *How long will the storm last?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 4

Explaining a New Policy

Context: Your organization introduces a new recycling program.

Communicator Task: Explain the policy benefits and steps clearly.

Public Questions:

- *Why is this necessary?*
- *Will it cost us more?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 5

Handling Misinformation

Context: A rumor spreads that tap water is unsafe, but it's not true.

Communicator Task: Correct misinformation calmly and provide facts.

Public Questions:

- *I saw it online—how do I know you're telling the truth?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 6

Budget Announcement

Context: Your department announces a budget cut that affects community programs.

Communicator Task: Explain the reason for the cut and reassure the public about essential services.

Public Questions:

- *Will my program be canceled?*
- *Why are you cutting funding now?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 7

Public Safety Update

Context: A new traffic pattern is being implemented to reduce accidents.

Communicator Task: Explain the change and its benefits.

Public Questions:

- *Will this cause delays?*
- *How long will construction last?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 8

Responding to Negative Media Coverage

Context: A local news outlet reports inaccurate information about your organization.

Communicator Task: Address the misinformation professionally and restore trust.

Public Questions:

- *Is the report true?*
- *Why didn't you respond sooner?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

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SCENARIO 9

Promoting a New Service

Context: Your organization launches a new online payment system for utilities.

Communicator Task: Explain how to use it and its benefits.

Public Questions:

- *Is it secure?*
- *What if I don't have internet access?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 10

Crisis Communication

Context: A chemical spill occurs near a residential area.

Communicator Task: Inform residents about safety precautions and evacuation plans.

Public Questions:

- *Is my family safe?*
- *When can we return home?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

Facilitator Instructions

- Encourage participants to use plain language, empathy, and active listening.
- After each scenario, ask:
  - What worked well?
  - What could be improved?
- Reinforce clarity, respect, and accuracy as key principles.
- Allow time for feedback and discussion after each role-play.

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